

# Leighton Van Ness

AI Operations, Implementation & Customer-Facing Systems Lead

New York, NY | 203.564.0116 | [leighton@vanness.net](mailto:leighton@vanness.net) | [LinkedIn](#) | [GitHub](#) | [Portfolio](#)

## SUMMARY

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AI operations, implementation, sales-enablement, and customer-facing systems leader with more than 10 years of experience building operational platforms, GTM workflows, client programs, and AI-enabled processes. Partner with sales teams and enterprise customers to translate business needs into dependable systems and delivery across CRM workflows, account programs, events, and post-sale execution. Combine hands-on technical fluency across APIs, modern web platforms, CRM systems, analytics, and deployment workflows with deep experience supporting high-value customer relationships.

## EXPERIENCE

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### Elevate Experiences | VP, Innovation

New York, NY | 2024 - Present

- Built and manage the Elevate Dashboard, a shared operations platform for event planning, ticketing, user administration, vendor and talent coordination, and production management.
- Developed the platform with React, serverless Node.js APIs, Redis/Upstash, Google Sheets integrations, and role-based access controls on Vercel.
- Established CI/CD, preview deployments, automated tests, production safeguards, PDF/Word exports, and recurring release verification.
- Lead AI and workflow implementation, evaluating tools, piloting practical use cases, and helping non-technical teams incorporate AI into day-to-day operating workflows.
- Built a custom, end-to-end AI sales agent using ChatGPT, Instantly, MailerLite, APIs, and multi-domain email infrastructure to automatically build targeted prospect lists, research and qualify leads, personalize and run cold-outreach sequences, manage sending operations, and synchronize lead and engagement data with CRM workflows.
- Serve on the account teams for two of Elevate's largest enterprise clients, each representing seven figures in annual business. Meet periodically with customers to understand future needs, strengthen relationships through in-person programs, and support delivery onsite.
- Translate customer needs into reliable execution by ensuring the systems and back-end workflows I built perform effectively across these client programs and responding to operational needs before and during events.
- Lead technical and back-end execution for approximately 25 virtual events and 5-10 private concerts and large-format experiences annually, coordinating talent, vendors, logistics, production teams, and client stakeholders.
- Led the Elevate Experiences website launch and now manage SEO, analytics, content, inquiry flows, and HubSpot- and Salesforce-connected workflows supporting sales handoffs and customer delivery.
- Built an automated logistics tracker supporting approximately 60 events, 600 shipped bins, and 12,000-24,000 items through status synchronization, alerts, routing, recap communications, and recovery workflows.

## **Zinc Agency | VP, Innovation & Technology**

*New York, NY | 2020 - 2024*

- Led the company's pivot to virtual programming during COVID, building the technical infrastructure that preserved client delivery and expanded the company's virtual-event offerings.
- Engineered a custom streaming and registration platform using WordPress, JavaScript, web APIs, embedded meeting tools, and reusable branded event workflows.
- Implemented Hive as the division's core project-management system, creating custom workflows, forms, automations, and Salesforce-connected operating structures still used across Zinc Agency and Elevate Experiences.
- Supported more than 2,000 celebrity-led livestreams, working directly with corporate clients to translate program goals into technical specifications and coordinating talent, platform, production, and operational stakeholders through delivery.
- Repurposed the virtual infrastructure into InviteMeNow, a customizable registration system for in-person, virtual, and hybrid client experiences.

## **Zinc Agency | Director of Products**

*New York, NY | 2018 - 2020*

- Led budget creation, experience pricing, product packaging, and sales strategy for premium entertainment and experiential offerings.
- Managed contracts, legal agreements, talent and venue requirements, and critical coordination among corporate clients, artists, representatives, and event stakeholders.

## **Creative Artists Agency | Account Executive**

*New York, NY | 2014 - 2018*

- Worked directly with corporate buyers to develop talent-led experiential concepts and programs aligned with client goals and budgets.
- Coordinated agency, venue, transportation, concierge, talent, and production requirements needed to carry sold programs through successful delivery.
- Managed client communication and cross-functional execution throughout planning and delivery for premium corporate programs.

## **TECHNICAL & AI SKILLS**

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**AI & Automation:** ChatGPT, Claude, OpenClaw, AI agents, sales prospecting automation, prompt/workflow design, research automation, API integrations, Apps Script, Zapier

**Platforms & GTM Systems:** Salesforce, HubSpot, ZoomInfo, Outreach, Instantly, MailerLite, multi-domain email infrastructure, Google Analytics, SEO

**Product Engineering:** HTML, CSS, JavaScript, TypeScript, React, Node.js, Express, REST APIs, GraphQL, Convex, Redis, MongoDB, MySQL, Sanity, Tailwind CSS, Vite

**Cloud, Delivery & Quality:** Vercel, Netlify, Render, AWS fundamentals, GitHub, CI/CD, Playwright, Jest, authentication and permissions, deployment verification

**Business Tools:** Google Workspace, Microsoft 365

## **EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS**

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CU Boulder - M.S. Computer Science, Estimated Completion 2026

New York University - Management, 2011 - 2013

University of St. Andrews - Economics, 2009 - 2011

Columbia Engineering Coding Boot Camp Professional Certificate, 2024

IBM Full Stack Software Developer Professional Certificate, 2023